

"Women! ... What have you **received** from the **Revolution?**"

OLYMPE DE GOUGES, FRENCH WRITER AND ACTIVIST,
DECLARATION OF THE RIGHTS OF WOMAN, 1791

QUESTIONING THE REVOLUTION

In 1789, rioting began in Paris over the price and scarcity of bread. As the mob grew more agitated and violent, nearly 7,000 women stole weapons from the city's armory and marched to Versailles. There, they besieged the palace, forcing the king and his ministers to return to Paris. This signaled the beginning of the end for Louis XVI, who was now called upon to answer to his critics. The writer Olympe de Gouges saw that while women played an active part in the uprisings, after the revolutionaries came to power women were still excluded from active citizenship. This inspired de Gouges to write her *Declaration of the Rights of Woman*, which set out a list of rights that all women should have. For example, since women could be executed at the guillotine, she believed they should also have the right to speak publicly about political matters. However, de Gouges was punished by Jacobin revolutionaries (see pp.130-133) for airing these views, and like many other well-known political women, she was executed in 1793.

